India, including its more aggressive posture at the India–China border, where relative peace and tranquillity had prevailed over the past several decades. In 2005, China was willing to make some concessions to India in order to forestall an incipient Indo–US alliance that could be threatening to China. Its reaction to the Quad, which is a coalition of India, Australia, Japan and the US, which could constrain China in the Indo-Pacific, is to dismiss its relevance and to adopt an even more threatening posture towards the coalition partners.

In the aftermath of the global financial and economic crisis of 2008, the Chinese assessment is that the US is a declining power, that its credibility is eroded and, importantly, that its will to exercise power has also diminished. It is a power in retreat and, therefore, allies and partners of the US, the Chinese assert, cannot count on US power to deter China. A narrative is being built on the inevitability of Chinese regional, and eventually global, dominance, which it would be futile to resist.

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